

Application Guidelines FAIR Competence Funding (2nd call)

July 2026

FAIR¹ Competence Funding is a funding scheme for Research Data Management (RDM) and/or Research Software Engineering (RSE) specialists who wish to develop their expertise and increase their influence within the ETH Zurich research community.

Introduction

This second call is open to all ETH Zurich members who work with research data and/or in research software development. All RDM and RSE specialists are eligible to apply:

- Research Software Engineers
- Research Data Managers
- Data Stewards
- Digital Curators/Archivists
- Technical personnel
- Researchers with relevant RDM/RSE responsibilities.

Applicants should:

- Handle research data and/or code as part of their work
- Seek to strengthen their competencies to meet FAIR standards
- Have ideas for outreach and offering expertise to a broader research community.

Objective

Building on the experience of the first call in 2026, the FAIR Competence Funding aims to:

- Support RDM/RSE specialists in upskilling their data stewardship and/or research software engineering capabilities, ensuring these skills contribute to long-term institutional capacity.
- Promote sustainable FAIR practices that can be shared across ETH Zurich and beyond, fostering collaboration and knowledge exchange.
- Strengthen the long-term provision of FAIR-related RDM/RSE services to meet the needs of clearly targeted research communities, so that tailored expertise and support remain available beyond the project duration.

General Terms and Conditions

Eligibility Criteria

- Be employed at ETH Zurich for the duration of the project.
- Provide two support letters from group leaders or heads of units (one must be the direct superior), from one or multiple ETH departments or non-departmental units (technology platforms or competence centres).
- Commit to sign the ETH FAIR Coalition Charter and to contribute actively to the activities of the ETH Zurich Data Stewardship Network and/or of the ETH Chapter of the Research Software Engineering Community.

¹ FAIR: Findability, Accessibility, Interoperability, and Reuse of digital research assets (<https://www.go-fair.org>).

Please note:

- Doctoral students are not eligible for funding.
- Funding is restricted to active RDM/RSE specialists, not group leaders or head of units.
- Applicants can submit only one application per call.
- If a previous application was rejected, substantial improvements to the proposal must have been made to be reconsidered.

Budget and Duration

- Maximum duration: 12 months
- Maximum funding: CHF 50'000. Projects with smaller budgets are encouraged.

Eligible Costs

Personnel costs (including salaries) are not eligible.

Funding may cover:

- Fees for RDM/RSE specialisation
- Costs for participation in courses or workshops. Please note, fees will be covered for a training and/or educational resource such as those listed in the Inventory of training and education resources in Data Stewardship/Research Data Management and/or in the Curated list of RSE-related courses and lectures, or for a similar course or programme that is specified in the application and for which the price is known.
- Development and enhancement of tools and/or services supporting FAIR practices at ETH Zurich
- Outreach and knowledge transfer activities (events, workshops, conferences)
- Membership fees for (inter)national networks or organisations
- Travel to and participation in conferences/workshops related to FAIR principles.

For details, see the Annex on “Budgeting Guidelines and Eligible Costs”.

How to Apply

Submit the complete proposal by Tuesday, 15 September, 17:00 CET in PDF format by email to openscience@sl.ethz.ch. Late or incomplete submissions will be rejected.

Use the proposal template provided. The proposal must include:

- Summary
- Applicant's achievements and current competencies (max. 1 page per applicant)
- Project details: rationale, planned activities, long-term strategy, added value to ETH Zurich (max. 3 pages)
- Budget table and justification
- Two support letters from research group/unit leaders in one or multiple ETH departments or in non-departmental units (technology platforms or competence centres).
- The applicant's superior must confirm support for the applicant's participation in the project. An additional letter may be attached if necessary.

Evaluation Procedure and Criteria

Applications are evaluated by the ETH Zurich FAIR Board:

- Applicant² suitability: 20% of the evaluation (section 1)
- Project quality: 80% (section 2).

² If there are two or more co-applicants, the suitability of the team will be assessed.

Projects submitted to the 2nd call are expected to include well-thought-out community-building activities (section 2.2 below).

A balanced project is expected, with the individual sub-chapters of the project (2.1 to 2.5) being given equal weighting. The following table provides an overview of the structure and expected content of the proposal:

1. Applicant (weight 20%)
1.1 The applicant's past work related to research, RDM, RSE, ORD, FAIR
Criterion: Demonstrated experience applying good practice in research data/code management and open science.
Examples: • Relevant projects or research domains are clearly described. • Evidence of managing data/code responsibly (planning, documentation, versioning, licensing). • Use or promotion of FAIR/ORD (e.g., depositing datasets/software, interoperable formats, metadata).
1.2 Ongoing RDM/RSE activities at ETH Zurich
Criterion: Active, meaningful contribution to ETH RDM/RSE community and culture.
Examples: • Concrete activities (e.g., Data Management Plans (DMP), data curation, repository deposits, training/support). • Beneficiaries (projects/groups) and outcomes are stated. • Engagement with ETH services/initiatives (Library/ID Scientific IT Services/ETH Research Collection, SDSC, CSCS), Data Stewardship Network and/or Research Software Engineering Community. • Workplace and current employment at ETH allow for the implementation of the project.
2. Project (weight 80%)
2.1 Relevance of digital research assets for ETH Zurich
Criterion: Clarity and relevance of the assets and FAIR needs addressed
Examples: • Specific assets (data, code, workflows, models, images) are identified. • FAIR gaps/needs (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable) are clearly framed. • Target communities at ETH Zurich are specified and appropriate.
2.2 Specific effort that will be funded by this call
Criterion: The appropriateness and innovativeness of the measures taken to address the identified need or gap.
Examples: • Innovative nature of the project. • Clear objectives for training and education for the applicant and how the new skills acquired will be used/shared. • Solution³ for a support tool and/or support service for research or teaching to be newly developed or extended as part of the project to support FAIR practices. • Community-building efforts (workshops, hackathons etc.) and outreach activities (social media, conferences, etc.), involving potentially several groups at ETH. • Credible impact for labs/groups and wider scientific community.
2.3 Work plan
Criterion: Effectiveness and coherence of implementation plan.
Examples: • Defined work packages with goals, approaches, and deliverables. • Realistic timeline/milestones (Gantt or equivalent). • Roles/responsibilities and chosen tools/technologies are appropriate.
2.4 Feasibility and risk assessment
Criterion: Realism and robustness of execution.
Examples: • Technical/organisational/financial risks are identified and prioritised. • Dependencies (partners/infrastructure) are explicit. • Mitigation and contingency plans are concrete and actionable.
2.5. Added value and impact of the project
Criterion: Added value for ETH Zurich
Examples: • New services that will be available as a result of the project, also after the project has ended.

³ FAIR RDM/RSE solutions understood in a broad sense: any FAIR software, database, collection, service, HPC, server or storage infrastructure, open lab space, open hardware, etc. that serves an existing or intended research community at ETH Zurich.

- Clear benefits for research or teaching.
- New researchers, groups and/or research communities and networks that are specifically targeted and potentially supported with the expertise and services developed.
- Institutional responsibility beyond project duration clearly assigned.
- Sustainable model for assets and competencies (who, how, with what resources).
- Future contribution to the Data Stewardship Network and/or Research Software Engineering Community.

Decision and Project Start

Funding decisions are made by the Vice President for Research based on the FAIR Board recommendations. Projects must start within two months of the decision. Funds will be managed through the superior's research group or unit account, with the grantee given the role of the budget manager.

Reporting Requirements

The grantee must comply with the following reporting duties:

1. Final content report, within two months after the project end
2. Final financial report, also within two months after the project end.

Templates will be provided by the Research Initiatives and Infrastructure Office.

Open Science Requirements

- Projects must comply with the ETH Zurich Guidelines for Research Data Management
- Publications must comply with ETH Zurich's Open Access Policy
- The APC Funding page lists open access funding options provided by the ETH Library and available to grantees
- Research data and code for publication should be deposited in a FAIR repository; it is recommended to register a metadata-only item in the ETH Research Collection linking to the published datasets.
- Scientific code should be deposited in ETH GitLab
- Acknowledge funding: *"This work was supported by ETH Zurich FAIR Competence Funding."*

Ethical and Legal Compliance

Projects must comply with ETH Zurich's regulations on scientific integrity, export control, and research data management, including handling of data related to humans, animals, genetically modified organisms, pathogens, data subject to export control regulations, and research in developing countries.

Use of generative AI must follow the ETH Zurich Guide for Responsible Use of AI.

Annette Oxenius

Nina Buchmann

Vice President for Research ETH Zurich

Chair of FAIR Board

Annex: Budgeting Guidelines and Eligible Costs

The following costs are eligible for funding:

- Fees and travel expenses for attending courses and training.
- If a solution for a support tool and/or support service is required to be newly developed or extended as part of the project; its operating costs will be covered only until the end of the project. Purchases must be explained in the proposal.
- Subcontracting costs of no more than 20%.
- Costs for the organisation of conferences and workshops.
- Fees for participating in national and international networks or organisations.
- Travel expenses and conference/workshop participation fees related to the project.
- Other costs that are essential to the project and that are duly explained in the proposal.

Costs not eligible for funding:

- Personnel costs, including salaries of applicants or project staff, are not eligible and must not be included in the budget.
- Any cost of research activities.
- Costs that are already funded by a third party (e.g. by a research grant).
- Costs related to a service or tool that duplicates features of an existing service or tool at ETH Zurich or in the ETH Domain or a standard platform in use in the community.

Adjacent research costs, such as, data production/data collection and data analysis, research software/hardware development, may not be included.